IELTS Preparation Guide: Start Here

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Welcome! This pack contains a guide for each of the four IELTS modules: Listening, Reading, Writing and Speaking. Read this page first: it explains how to use the guides and how to plan your preparation.

How to prepare

Prepare two modules at a time, and practise them every day. Studying all four at once spreads your attention too thin; one module at a time leaves the others forgotten by test day. Two modules together, done consistently, builds real progress.

Pair the modules that support each other:

Phase	Modules	Why they go together	Suggested length
1	**Listening + Reading**	Both have 40 questions, use similar question types (completion, multiple choice, matching), and train you to spot paraphrase	3 weeks
2	**Writing + Speaking**	Both test how you express ideas; the vocabulary, linking words and sentence structures overlap	3 weeks
3	**All four modules**	Full timed mock tests to build stamina and fix weak areas	2 weeks

Keep revising Phase 1 lightly during Phase 2 (one listening or reading test a week), so those skills stay sharp.

The lengths are a guide. If your test date is closer, shorten each phase but keep the same order and keep practising daily.

What's in each module folder

Each module has its own folder with full instructions inside. Open the guide for the module you are working on and follow it step by step.

Folder	What the guide covers
Listening	Test format, question types, the rough-sheet numbering strategy, map vocabulary (with Urdu meanings), do's and don'ts, common traps, free practice links
Reading	Test format, question types, the "Passage 3 first" strategy and timing, skimming and scanning, True / False / Not Given, do's and don'ts, common traps, free practice links
Writing	Time plan (Task 2 first), Task 1 report types and structures, Task 1 vocabulary, Task 2 essay types and structures, phrases, topic vocabulary, do's and don'ts
Speaking	Questions on 17 common topics, sentence structures for Part 1 and Part 3, filler phrases for difficult questions, vocabulary for each topic

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Staying consistent

Consistency matters more than long study sessions: 1–2 focused hours every day beats 8 hours once a week.

- **Practise every day**, even on busy days. A single listening section or one essay plan keeps the habit alive.
- **Use a timer** for every practice test, so test-day timing feels normal.
- **Review every mistake.** Find out why the answer was wrong and write the lesson in a notebook.
- **Listen to English podcasts daily**, even for 15–20 minutes on the bus or while cooking. It trains your ear for different accents and speeds, which helps both Listening and Speaking.
- **Keep a vocabulary notebook** with new words, their synonyms and an example sentence.
- **Speak and write in English daily**: describe your day aloud, or write a short paragraph about any topic from the Speaking guide.
- **Track your scores** from each practice test to see your progress and find your weakest question types.
- **In the final week**, take at least two full mock tests in one sitting (Listening, Reading and Writing back to back), and rest well the night before the test.

Free IDP mock test

IDP runs **free mock tests** at its test centres, often on **Tuesdays** (the day varies by city, so check with your local IDP office and book a seat). Take at least one before your real test: it lets you experience the real test environment, including the room, the computers, the headphones and the timing.

Note that **IDP does not tell you your scores** from this mock test. Its purpose is familiarity with the environment, not a band score, so use the practice websites in each module guide to measure your level.

British Council vs IDP

There is no real difference in the test. IELTS is jointly owned by the British Council, IDP IELTS and Cambridge University Press & Assessment (IELTS official), so the questions, format, marking and certificate are the same whichever one you book with. Universities and visa offices accept both equally.

The only differences are practical, so choose whichever suits you:

Choose based on	What to compare
Location	Which test centre is closer to you
Dates	Which one has a test date that fits your plan
Format	Paper or computer availability at that centre
Extras	Free preparation material and mock tests each offers when you book

Questions?

For any queries, follow me and send a message on LinkedIn: Mehak Hussain on LinkedIn

Good luck with your preparation!

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